

Rudy Summers

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Dangerous Speech

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Thoughts on Flattery and the Problem of Counsel

The life of a king is plagued with problems. How best to rule, how to seek advice, how to choose what advice to follow, how to best implement hypothetical plans and procedures into the real world. And failure in any of those areas can easily lead to failures in the other ones, which can easily lead to a monarch becoming an ex-monarch. Due to this, kings are forced to acquire the assistance of others in order to rule effectively, and the process of doing so contains its own dangers.

In Thomas Hobbes' Leviathan, Hobbes talks about how kings seek the counsel of experts and the advantages that such assistance holds, as well as the issues that arise as a result. Hobbes contrasts the way that a sovereign monarch can receive advice with the way that a sovereign democracy is able to do so. Hobbes points out that a monarch, when seeking advice, can be very specific with who he receives advice from, when he does so, and how confidential the advice can be, while

assemblies are limited because only certain people are willing to present in front of an assembly, and they cannot do so secretly, or particularly far in advance, thus giving the monarch a distinct advantage in their ability to receive counsel (Hobbes, 116). After all, when ruling, flexibility is absolutely paramount, and keeping state secrets legitimately secret has obvious benefits. However, Hobbes also points out that the very nature of sovereignty, anyone who is brought in to counsel the king is less powerful than the monarch, and thus are in danger of losing their life, their possessions, and functionally anything of worth in their life (Hobbes, 116). This innate power imbalance is the source of the problem that makes monarchs, despite the flexibility in their ability to seek counsel, have such a difficult time receiving honest advice from those who they consult for assistance.

The problem here is obvious: although the king has the power to summon anyone to give him counsel, he is limited by the self preservation instincts of those he seeks counsel from. He can ask for the help of anyone within the range of his influence and power, and he can compel them to answer the questions he asks of them, but he cannot fundamentally change their nature. Since a king's anger can easily ensure that an advisor's life becomes remarkably shorter, it is in the advisor's best interests to prevent the king from being angry. If the truth would get you killed, and potentially cause the king to become too angry to meaningfully listen to it, what rational

individual would speak the truth? And as an extension, since the moods of the king are fickle, it becomes highly difficult to accurately predict when the king's anger will arise, and when one is able to tell the truth. In this manner, the goal of interactions with the king logically becomes to survive by telling the king what they want to hear, rather than to give the best advice possible, leading to flattery rather than frankness as a dominant strategy amongst advisors. Although there are individuals present in a king's court who do prioritize giving the best advice rather than flattering the king, they are not the norm.

This problem of counsel is well known, however. A large number of Mirror for Princes type literature extensively discuss the dangers of flatters, how to avoid them and surround oneself with individuals who do not succumb to the instinct of self preservation, or, at the very least, how a monarch should act in order to make their advisors feel safe in telling them the truth. Typically, these suggestions focus on being able to anticipate flattery, and realize when you're being flattered, as well as utilizing the power that a king naturally has access to in order to punish people who do flatter you. However, this presents a unique puzzle: by his nature, the only tools a king has is power he has over his subjects and his monopoly on violence. And while he can use those two tools in a variety of ways to try and solve the problem of

counsel, the problem arose in the first place because of said power over others. So in this way, does power solve the problems of the king, or create them?

In The Prince by Nicolo Machiavelli, Machiavelli devotes an entire chapter to the dangers of flatters and how to avoid them. He states that as long as members of the court have reason to fear telling the monarch the truth, there is no way to remove the the possibility that your advisors are consistently choosing flattery over frankness (Machiavelli, 114). Therefore, the logical decision would be to work hard to ensure that the members of the court do not in fact fear the monarch, likely doing so by making specific provisions so that people may speak freely without any risk of punishment.. However, Machiavelli raises an alternative problem with that attempted solution: if everyone feels comfortable speaking frank with a monarch all the time, and know that they can do so without fear of repercussions, then people gradually start to respect the ruler less. Machiavelli's advice on how to solve the problem of counsel is to choose a specific group of individuals, and granting only them the ability to speak the truth to the monarch freely, and only allow them to do so when the king directly asks them a question (Machiavelli, 114). This limits the powers that the ruler grants to those he seeks counsel from, preventing it from causing him to look weak, while simultaneously still making him look reasonable and merciful, and thus likely allowing said select individuals to be comfortable speaking the truth.

Machiavelli does stress that the ability to seek counsel should remain a power of the king, and that giving up the sovereign monarch's privilege of seeking counsel wherever, whenever, and from whoever they want is a very poor decision (Machiavelli, 115). A king benefits greatly from being able to seek the counsel of whoever he wishes, and giving it up would be as poor of a decision as any other instance of the king willingly giving up his power without a direct benefit from doing so.

In The Education Of A Christian Prince by Desiderius Erasmus similarly addresses flatterers, in particular focusing on princes, as short hand for a young and inexperienced ruler, which makes flatterers significantly more dangerous than they would be to a more experienced ruler. Erasmus condemns flatterers, suggesting that even though it is a minor evil to act as a flatter, it is evil nonetheless and is capable of destroying empires as well as contributing heavily to oppression (Erasmus, 193). Whereas Machiavelli framed flattery in terms of making the ruler's job more difficult, Erasmus poses flattery in moral terms, and condemns flatterers for their actions on a moral level. This morality also clearly leads into the way Erasmus proposes solutions to the problem. Erasmus' solution to the problem of counsel is to pick the advisors to the prince very carefully, and make it explicitly clear to them that their job is to be honest, and if circumstances change so that they can no longer speak

honestly for fear that they will be harmed, allow them to leave their office honorably at any point in time. This effectively fixes the problem where people who would otherwise be helpful advisors are driven to flattery out of self preservation. However, this doesn't offer a solution to those who seek to flatter the king in order to further their own personal political power. And so as an added level, he proposes that if an individual is caught lying to the monarch, they should be publicly punished as an example to others, even being executed if the lie was great enough (Erasmus, 194). Honest individuals and those who would only flatter out of self preservation have no reason to fear this punishment, as it wouldn't apply to them, and thus the only people who are scared into inaction are the exact group of people that it seeks to punish. These solutions must be implemented quickly, however, since Erasmus asserts that, without specifically warding against them, the prince is naturally totally surrounded by flatterers, and is incapable of receiving any honest advice or help (Erasmus, 195) and even people who are frank with the prince might only act frank in order to gain his favor (Erasmus, 203). Erasmus finally asserts that the only source a prince can truly trust is books, as the writer has no reason to flatter the prince (Erasmus, 203).

Fredrick of Prussia in the Anti-Machiavel also spends a chapter talking about flatterers, starting by acknowledging how thoroughly the topic has been discussed in

mirror for princes texts. Unlike some of the other texts, which attribute the effectiveness of flattery to flatterers being good at manipulating the king, or to the king assuming that advisors will tell him the truth, Fredrick suggests that expecting kings to love the truth above all else is almost asking too much of kings (Fredrick, 142). Kings can value truth, but ultimately, the most important thing to any king must be the success of their kingdom. And in order for them to ensure that their kingdom is successful, a king must take great pride in it. Fredrick suggests that flatters are so successful because kings, at their core, are prideful because the nature of the position forces them to be so, as they are expected to have enough pride to “seek after glory and at the same time be sufficiently self-effacing to give up the fruits of their labors,” (Fredrick, 142). And even if it was possible to abandon this pride, while it might make the king more resilient to flattery, it would certainly also have dire consequences to a king's ability to rule. And even if kings did love truth as much as other mirror for princes texts claim they do, even if truth was the single most important thing to any ruler's ability to rule, Fredrick points out that this wouldn't grant them immunity to flattery that was, at its core, the truth (Fredrick, 143). Flattery that doesn't leave the realm of reality, that is based on the king's legitimate accomplishments, cannot be rejected by any reasonable king, because doing so would require both a lack of pride and lack of value in the truth. And this type of flattery is not only possible, it is likely to be present, as long as the king in question

has any noteworthy accomplishments whatsoever, which is almost a guarantee.

Fredrick ends the chapter by stating that “It seems...more fair to pity kings than to condemn them. It is the flatterers and....the slanderers who merit the condemnation and hatred of the public, along with all the enemies of the princes who hide the truth from them.” (Fredrick, 143) This line seems somewhat strange, until one remembers that Fredrick, unlike Erasmus and Machiavelli, was a king himself. While the other writers were several layers of abstraction away from rulership, and more capable of simply asserting that a king must follow certain guidelines in order to fix the problems within their court, Fredrick was likely more personally concerned about his reputation as a king, and how that might suffer as a result of people’s perceptions of the manner in which he chose to address the problem of counsel.

Fredrick’s take on the problem of counsel differs quite heavily from both Erasmus’ as well as Machiavelli’s. While the others address the problem with a host of solutions, Fredrick argues that the problem of counsel cannot be fixed, or at least can’t be fixed realistically by the king himself. While he acknowledges that certain types of kings, such as those who spent at least part of their life as civilians, might be resilient to flattery (Fredrick, 143), he states simply that it’s impossible for those who have been praised their entire life to suddenly start resisting praise. Fredrick’s argument hinges on the idea that kings inherently must possess a degree of pride in

order to be effective kings, and that this pride supersedes or otherwise interferes with the king's ability to perceive the truth in the face of flattery. In essence, the position of kingship, in addition to naturally causing the rise of flatterers in the courtroom, naturally makes it impossible for the king to get rid of such flatterers without large amounts of outside help. This pride becomes another crucial element in the problem of counsel, as acknowledging it allows greater insight into why the problem might not be so easily solved.

Part of the problem, proposed in all of the texts, is that the problem of counsel is an inherent flaw in kingship, and not one that is naturally avoidable. But it's pervasiveness, and the ability of the king to remove it, differs wildly. Fredrick and Machiavelli seem to be on the same page, that active flatterers make up the majority of the court, and can manipulate the king into ignoring the few individuals who aren't flatterers, while Erasmus argues that the king is, unless they actively ward against flatterers, will be completely surrounded by them and will be incapable of receiving honest advice or help. Before even analyzing how a king is meant to free themselves from these circumstances, it is worth considering why the texts would disagree on the prevalence of flatterers. After all, the conditions remain more or less the same, the king has power over the subjects and those subjects fear for their lives, so why does the amount differ? Simply put: when Fredrick, Machiavelli, and

Erasmus use the term “prince”, they are referring to slightly different things. Fredrick typically uses it interchangeably with king, while Machiavelli uses prince to refer to the position and king to refer to individual sovereigns. On the other hand, Erasmus specifically is talking about someone young, and inexperienced, taking the throne when he uses the word prince. When a ruler is new to the throne, especially if they are younger, they are more likely to behave erratically than a seasoned ruler, and are thus more likely to give their subjects a reason to fear them. In addition, if Fredrick is to be believed, younger princes are more easily to be manipulated, as they gradually build a reliance on flattery, and become unable to function without it. So, while on a surface level it might seem that Erasmus disagrees with Fredrick or Machiavelli with regards to the prevalence of flattery, their beliefs all line up, once a little effort is spent decoding them.

Ultimately the question inherent in the problem of counsel concerns identifying the causes behind it, and working to try and fix them. The causes, however, end up being two things that cannot easily be changed: the desire to survive, and the power imbalances inherent in monarch/civilian interactions. Machiavelli and Erasmus propose solutions, but their solutions make the deeper philosophical parts simply more confusing. Although they give ways for a monarch to potentially either give people incentives not to flatter him (making it so that their desire to survive leads

them to not flatter, rather than to flatter, by threatening violence upon them if they make the mistake of flattering the king) or to isolate oneself from flatterers (make a separate counsel that knows they can speak truthfully and safely), they're offering cures to symptoms rather than ways to actually address the core problem. And on top of that, the solutions rely on the king leveraging his power and monopoly on violence in order to change the behaviors of people to more closely align with what he wants. Which is paradoxical, as that same monopoly on violence and power over others is what caused the situation to arise in the first place. It is here that Fredrick's point regarding kings being fundamentally unable to escape flatters starts to make more sense.

If we examine the nature of kings as Fredrick views them, they are defined by two primary qualities: a pride in their own work, and tremendous power over others. As additional quality, they also will seek truth, but not when it contradicts their pride or jeopardizes their power to do so. This creates the perfect situation for flattery to arise, as a king with pride would not wish to be insulted, and a king with power has means to incentivize people to not insult him. However, once flattery begins, a king with pride would be reluctant to admit that people are flattering him, as it puts all the praise that he received into question, and thus potentially robs him of large amounts of personal glory.

Forcing the king to have a revelation that would lead him to admit that his court is filled with flatters is a task that is far harder than most mirror for princes texts are willing to acknowledge. Erasmus proposes that such a revelation would have to come from books, as books freely give advice that advisors would be reluctant to give (Erasmus, 199), and the writers of said books have no reason to flatter the prince (Erasmus, 203). And yet, Erasmus also acknowledges that there are a number of books in existence that would be detrimental for a prince to read, as they could corrupt and manipulate him in manners entirely different than flatterers, yet no less dangerous. Of course, Erasmus lays out a veritable curriculum for a prince to read in order to become a good prince, but it does raise a question: if reading books for advice can be as dangerous as Erasmus claims, how can a prince trust mirror for princes texts such as Erasmus' own or Machiavelli's? How can he discern the good ones, which will lead him to success, from the bad ones, which act as pitfalls to bring about his ruin? And why on earth should he trust them instead of his advisors, given that he picked his advisors, and Erasmus acknowledges that books can be as duplicitous as a member of the court? Wouldn't trusting books lead the prince into the same trap as trusting any member of his court would, leading him to question their every word? Erasmus' suggestion for how a prince ought to escape the cycle of flattery initially clearly is flawed, which makes Fredrick's point additionally salient.

And yet, while none of the texts seem to give a satisfactory way of escaping flattery, all of them repeatedly make it explicitly obvious that flattery is incredibly dangerous and damaging to a prince's ability to rule as well as their reputation. While blatant flattery can be recognized and rebuked by any intelligent king, flattery that seeks to conform to the prince's biases and interests is much harder to resist. And yet both types have an equal potential of damaging the kingdom. As the prince's judgement becomes clouded by flattery, the way that power is distributed changes. While the sovereign power never truly changes in who holds it, it is possible for it to be altered who effectively has the ability to utilize it. While a flatterer has no official authority, the ability to influence a king's decision making skills is undeniably power. However, the danger inherent here is obvious: flatterers naturally twist the way that the prince is able to use his power, and effectively cause the prince to lose the power of counsel as normally granted to him by his sovereign power, and thus hugely limit the power of the king. Flatterers who are subtle can quickly cause untold damages, simply by taking the ability to rule into their own hands, and leading by means of counsel, without any counsel for themselves.

Applied versions of Machiavellian texts are even more explicit about the dangers of flattery, as they give specific real world examples where flattery caused a nation to

fall apart. And worse, in applied texts, the flatterers usually have more of a goal in mind than the flatterers in mirror for princes texts, who simply want to survive. And this specific goal can cause infinitely more trouble, as the actions that they will take to serve that goal are by necessity more drastic than actions that they would need to take in order to survive. In William Cavendish's An English Prince, Cavendish lays out common errors of the state, citing one of the critical ones as "that the factions at Court were not suppressed." (Cavendish, 150) Cavendish explains the fall of the past two kings before his current majesty, Charles the Second, in the context of how they controlled their court, or rather how they failed to do so. Within the court, Cavendish explains, a single weak faction set out to weaken the other factions amongst the court. Initially, doing so involved simply spreading rumors amongst the court, and while such action caused strife and problems, they were a matter of the dangers of faction, rather than the problem of counsel. However, Cavendish points out that the greatest problem with this was the influence that the court's rumors had. Given that the court, and factions within it, could ruin the lives and reputations of those they viewed as antithetical to their beliefs, they could consequently limit the king's ability to select those individuals to counsel him, as the king would be unwilling to seek out counsel from individuals who were reviled by the court. In addition, Cavendish notes that once the court obtains the ability to tear down individuals from a position of power, then the king's position becomes jeopardized,

as his courtiers have the ability to threaten his power, a threat that cannot go unanswered (Cavendish, 151). While this specific problem has significant overlap with other issues of state, its source is the ability of the court to talk freely, and as a result of personal agendas undermine the king, which links back to the problem of counsel clearly.

And so Cavendish points out yet another potential pitfall in the rapidly spiraling out of control problem of counsel. Already, a king must be concerned about whether or not his advisors are telling him the truth, but on top of that, he must be acutely concerned about their motivations, whether or not they are actively advising him. In Cavendish's circumstance, the court did have power, as it was a parliamentary system, so a truly monarchical ruler could afford to be less concerned, but it is a potential flaw worth considering and being prepared to address. However, Cavendish's circumstance is one that has an answer to it. If the king had limited the courtiers influence, or punished their abuses of power swiftly and harshly, then it is unlikely that the courtiers would have been able to act in such a manner. And so thus, once again, a king's power and monopoly on violence becomes his one saving grace. However, Cavendish acknowledges that one of the reasons that the king didn't act was likely due to a lack of knowledge of the events that were occurring, once again raising the question of how kings are meant to properly manage their

courts if they are kept outside of the loop. These two recurring paradoxical problems, the fact that power can solve the problems that arise naturally due to its existence, and the king's lack of knowledge preventing him from acquiring knowledge, are clearly crucial to better understanding the problem of counsel in a way that actually allows it to be solved.

Ultimately, however, Cavendish's points, while factually correct, are less relevant in the context of the other mirror for princes texts. Cavendish doesn't address the conceptual ideas proposed by Machiavelli or his contemporaries, but instead simply attempts to apply Machiavellian theories to problems that he has observed within the court of the king, and to pass these observations onto the current sovereign in an attempt to give real world examples for the political theory advice. It doesn't pursue the logic behind why such things occurred, or attempt to give more widely applicable insight, and attempting to apply Cavendish's thoughts to kingdoms everywhere has the potential to be highly inaccurate in application.

Ultimately, if you were a king looking for guidance, these texts don't actually give you that many options to deal with the problem of counsel, especially if you are surrounded from all angles by all sorts of flatterers. Fredrick proposes that there are no specific patterns of behavior that can be taken for a king to render themselves

immune to flattery, unless they give up some of the elements, such as pride, that make them good kings. Fredrick's proposal is to just attempt to deal with it as best as possible, and to be conscious that there might be individuals seeking to manipulate you in order to serve themselves. Beyond that, he gives no specific advice. This advice of accepting that a king will be influenced by flatterers, and that there is nothing that they can do to protect themselves from it, is highly unhelpful, particularly for texts of this era. And while the other mirror for princes texts technically offer advice, the options they give are worrisomely limited. Erasmus makes it clear that a king cannot trust anyone, as everyone that they talk to, whether they speak frankly or whether they flatter the king could potentially be a flatterer, albeit one who attempts to convince the king that they can be trusted. And although Erasmus says that books can sometimes be trusted to tell the king the truth, he simultaneously acknowledges that some books will deceive the king or lead him down dangerous paths. And beyond the simple question of trust, Erasmus' advice requires a king paradoxically be merciful, yet unbearably harsh. And Machiavelli's advice is to stop trusting one's advisors, and create a separate group of advisors, one that you can ensure are telling you the truth by making them feel safe, and consult the second group whenever a circumstance is actually dire enough. Ultimately, none of these options is particularly appealing, and all of them have elements of just giving up and accepting the problem as unfixable to some degree.

However, all of them are offering advice with the goal of being widely applicable. The goal of these mirror for princes texts is not to give the perfect solution to individual problems of court, but to give a general series of suggestions in order to try and fix problems that all kings will at some point run into. However, the problem with attempting to fix the problem of counsel is that each instance of it is hugely context dependent. Depending on the individuals that populate the court, depending on the motivations of the individuals, depending on how threatening the king actually is, the behavior of flatterers can radically vary, and the prevalence of them can range from everywhere to only a handful within the entire court. There isn't a one size fits all solution, and there isn't even a single approach that will work regardless.

Sometimes, a king acting more lenient can cause the flatterers to attempt to take even further control of the court, as Machiavelli warned against, but other times a king acting excessively harsh will ensure that he will never be able to remove the problem of counsel, as people will become thoroughly terrified of their king's anger. However, while there isn't an automatic solution in this manner, perhaps it would've been best if the texts had made that clear. While they would have lost some legitimacy by acknowledging they didn't have all the answers, if they had given advice for each situation, that would have likely served the purpose of teaching king's how to rule better more effectively.

Alternatively, there is the option of paranoia. A king without counsel will of course eventually destroy his own kingdom, but a king who relies on as few people as possible, removing as many opportunities for flattery, has a higher chance of avoiding flatterers. Because although it might seem as though it would be helpful to have redundancy within one's court, so that you have advisors interested in telling you the truth to potentially alert you to the presence of flattery, the larger the court is, the greater the chance of flatterers. And the practice of flattery encourages the presence of further flatterers; after all, if the king has been lied to enough, and given a misguided and optimistic outlook on the current state of affairs, the first person to tell him so would likely be the focus of an immediate and overwhelming amount of anger and suspicion from the king, which isn't a position that most people would want to be in. In addition, there is the cautionary tale that Cavendish shared with us regarding the dangers inherent in having too populous a court: the tendency for factions to arise is a very real and potent danger, and the problems therein outweigh the benefits. So, logically, the correct decision would be to trust as few people as possible. This is most similar to Machiavelli's solution, although Machiavelli suggests that the king in question keep the court, and just rely on them significantly less. Another potential option would be to have a small group of trusted counsel that is changed regularly. As long as individuals in the group know that they won't have any long term influence, and have no control over their ability to be a member of the

counsel or any control over the ability of their political enemies, as well as having no reason to fear for their lives, the most dangerous parts of political flattery are gone.

Without a doubt, the problem of counsel is incredibly treacherous and complicated, largely due to the paradoxical nature of both its causes and its solutions. While the power of counsel is caused by a king having too much power, and those who he chooses to advise him having little power and fearing for their lives, it is solved by either denying those same advisors power or by giving them different reasons to fear for their lives. While a king's pride might make him susceptible to flatterers, removing that pride makes him unfit to rule. While a king's greatest power is his ability to call upon anyone he chooses to give him counsel, at any time he wishes to, regardless of the circumstance, utilizing that ability improperly can be the single greatest mistake a king makes. And of course, while a king that trusts everyone will fail, so too will a king that trusts no one. And although there are solutions, none of them treat the problem, but merely its symptoms. Or the ones that treat the problem itself, such as treating your advisors with kindness, warn of the danger inherent in doing so, as kindness can quickly become weakness as far as sovereign power goes.

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